published in the mid-1880s, which stated that the Dravidians were the original indigenous people of India. According to its author, the Madras civil servant Charles Maclean, there were a number of circumstances which suggested that 'the primeval home of man was a continent now sunk below the surface of the Indian ocean ... given the name Lemuria. By assuming Lemuria to have been man's primeval home, the explanation of the geographical distribution of the human species is much facilitated ... Southern India was once the passage-ground by which the ancient progenitors of northern and Mediterranean races proceeded to the parts of the globe which they now inhabit.'[13]

So the Lemuria theory caught on, gaining further credibility when it was picked up by the founder of the Theosophical Movement, the occultist Madame Blavatsky, and promoted by her in her esoteric teachings, reaching its most bizarre apotheosis in the writings of three of her disciples: Charles Leadbeater, William Scott-Elliott (author of *The Lost Lemuria*, 1904) and Rudolf Steiner (author of *Cosmic Memory: Prehistory of Earth and Man*, 1959). Ridiculous as many of the ideas promoted under the aegis of the Theosophical Society now appear, the relocating of its headquarters from New York to Madras in 1895, coupled with the wholehearted support given to the Indian home rule movement by the Theosophist, political activist and social reformer Annie Besant, ensured that Theosophy and those same ideas about the lost continent of Lemuria found a place in the hearts of many South Indians.

Kumarikkantam and Ilemuriakkantam fitted very neatly into the new Tamil self-image as promoted by the Tamil revivalists in the early decades of the twentieth century, because it accorded with their own perceptions of the Sangam golden age. These revivalists spearheaded what became known as the Thanittamil Iyakkam, or 'Pure Tamil